

ASSESSMENT: Settlement Journey of Calgary, AB, Canada

November 2023

in Newcomers

2023

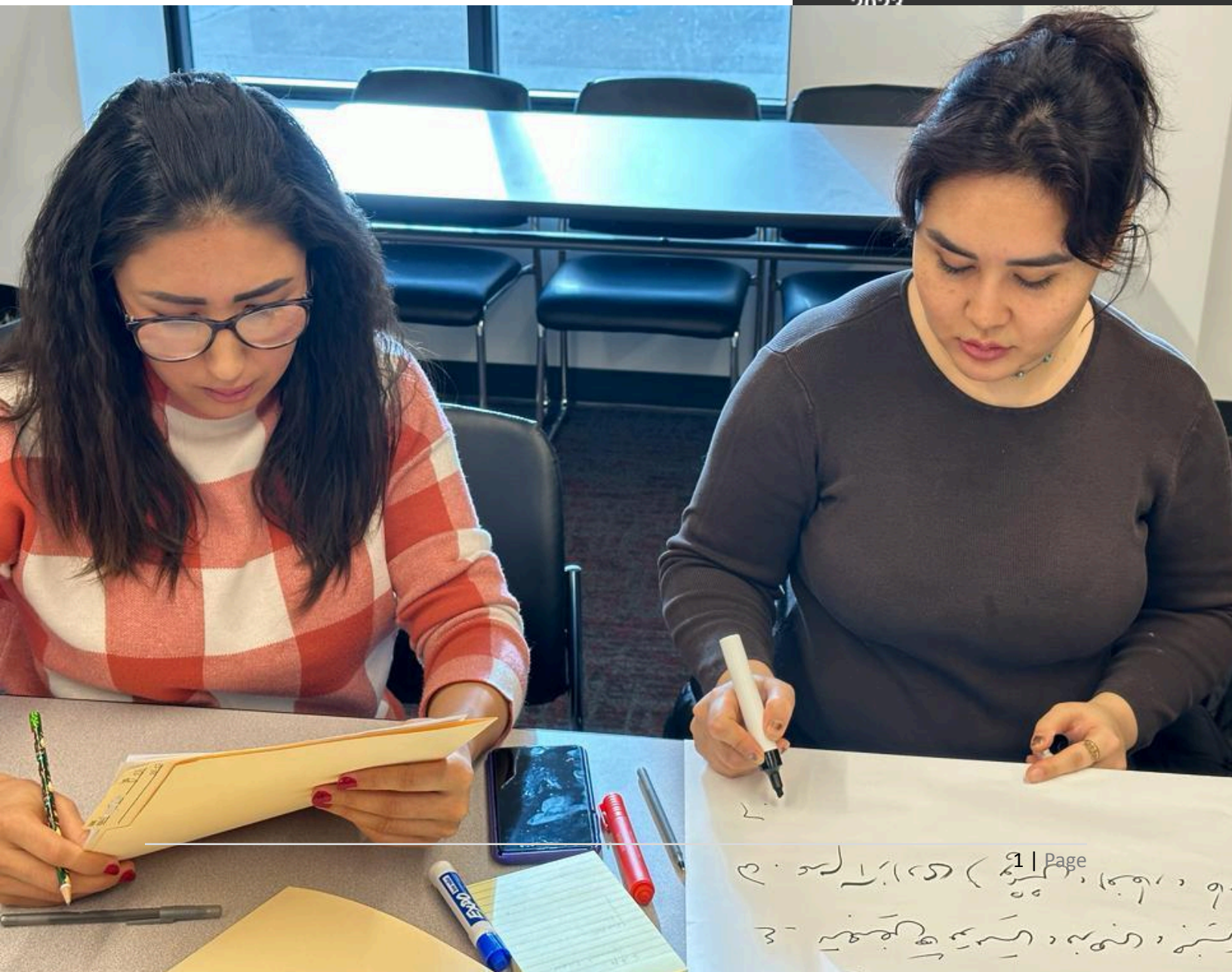


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I. ABBREVIATIONS

1. AB: Alberta
2. IQAS: International Qualifications Assessment Service
3. WES: World Education Services
4. LINC: Language Instruction for Newcomers to Canada
5. Likert: Likert Scale, a psychometric scale commonly used in surveys to measure attitudes and opinions.

II. ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

This note is to acknowledge the time and contributions of 52 Afghan Newcomers, including men and women, who responded to the survey questionnaires.

My special gratitude goes to my husband, Hamidullah Muazam, who has supported me during the entire cycle of this study, and his hands-on contribution to reviewing reports and for enhancing language-editing contributions to this report.

I would like to thank Mr. Ahmad Nasim Dawar for his contribution to checking the data analysis. His technical assistance and feedback in data management made this possible to reduce the margin of errors.

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Calgary, AB, Canada
November 2023

III. INTRODUCTION

The Federal Government of Canada has resettled over 40,000 Afghan refugees in Canada through several special measures and programs¹. Of which 5,245 refugees were destined in Calgary, AB, Canada under government-assisted refugees (GARs), and private sponsorship refugees (PSRs) streams².

This survey has been meticulously crafted with a distinct purpose: to meticulously collect essential insights regarding the multifaceted experiences of Afghan newcomers who have consciously chosen Calgary, Alberta, as their new place of residence. The design and execution of this survey have been specifically honed to create a comprehensive and inclusive platform, offering Afghan newcomers an opportunity to express their distinctive viewpoints, confront the challenges they encounter, and articulate their aspirations as they navigate the transformative path of resettlement and integration in a foreign cultural and geographical landscape that markedly differs from their home country.

In the last couple of years, Calgary has witnessed an influx of Afghan newcomers and those refugees who have received their Canadian citizenships, seeking a better life. Their settlement and integration process at some point remained a complex and challenging journey, encompassing various aspects of life, such as housing, employment, community engagement, and overall well-being.

The purpose of this study is to help refugee supporting organizations gain a deeper understanding of the unique challenges and opportunities Afghan newcomers encounter in their efforts to become integral members of Calgary. The insights gathered from this assessment will be instrumental in shaping policies, programs, and services aimed at facilitating the successful settlement and integration of Afghan newcomers in Calgary, AB.

As per plan and the commitment to uphold survey excellence and to facilitate more informed decision-making, this study undertook extensive tasks including desk reviews and conducting a comprehensive online survey.

The data collection methodology employed for this survey was defined by its precise nature. This approach held the utilization of two distinct data collection techniques, namely, *the on-site (on the ground) and desk review methodologies* ensuring a robust and thorough approach to gathering data. The methodology was designed to elicit high-quality responses, ensuring that the information obtained is reliable, representative, and reflective of the target population's perspectives.

While the original target population was designated at 55 individuals, it is pivotal to recognize the slight variation in participation, ultimately involving 52 participants. This subtle deviation carries significance, as it influences the interpretation and implications of the study's findings. The success rate of 94% underscores the reliability of the dataset, attesting to the credibility of the insights gained.

In the subsequent sections of this report, we will delve into the detailed analysis of the data collected and present an insightful exploration of the findings. These findings have the potential to make a meaningful contribution to improving refugee and newcomers' lives and to serve as a resource for informed decision-making. The survey questionnaires have been methodically organized into four distinct sections, with each section thoughtfully addressing pivotal facets of the survey's scope. These sections provide a comprehensive examination of housing, employment, and education, while the fourth

¹ Welcome Afghans: <https://www.canada.ca/en/immigration-refugees-citizenship/services/refugees/afghanistan.html>

² Key Figures: <https://www.canada.ca/en/immigration-refugees-citizenship/services/refugees/afghanistan/key-figures.html#communities>

section is expressly designed to elicit recommendations and insights from the survey participants. The comprehensive findings are presented in the subsequent sections of this report.

IV. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This report comprises four key sections, each shedding light on the multifaceted challenges faced by Afghan newcomers in Canada. In the housing domain, these challenges encompass high rent costs, discrimination, unfamiliarity with the Canadian housing system, and a lack of credit history, which are further complicated for those with larger families. The report underscores the need for comprehensive support and resources to facilitate their integration.

Regarding the regional distribution of survey participants, a majority reside in the northeast, accounting for 56%. The diversity of residential preferences is evident, with single houses and apartments being equally favored living arrangements by 31% each.

Survey participants express varying levels of satisfaction with their housing, with 40% reporting high satisfaction. However, a portion of newcomers still face challenges. Many took months to secure housing, with 56% interacting directly with landlords, while others relied on resettlement agencies, service providers, or friends.

In the employment section, the report highlights the significance of facilitating the integration of newcomers into the Canadian workforce. While 62% of participants are not currently employed, 38% are actively engaged in the job market. The majority of those employed work full-time, and respondents outline challenges like inflation, language barriers, and limited job opportunities.

Education plays a pivotal role in newcomers' resettlement, with 58% holding high school diplomas. Despite holding higher degrees, a significant portion have not evaluated their qualifications by World Education Services (WES) and International Qualifications Assessment Service (IQAS). Further, 75% have not applied for educational continuation in Canada. The report emphasizes the importance of addressing challenges such as language proficiency and document certification.

In the recommendations section, participants provide practical guidance for housing, education, and employment support. They emphasize the need for comprehensive resources and tailored services for newcomers, including affordable housing, job opportunities, and language support.

Ultimately, these insights contribute to a better understanding of the challenges faced by Afghan newcomers in Canada, highlighting the importance of comprehensive support and resources to ensure their successful integration into Canadian society.

V. DEMOGRAPHICS:

Survey participants have been categorized into four distinct age brackets, spanning from 15 to 30, 31 to 40, 41 to 50 years, and those aged 50 or older. Notably, the age group falling within the range of 31 to 40 constitutes the largest cohort of participants in this survey, as illustrated in the graph presented below.

Table 1: Contribution of survey participants by age category

S#	Age categories	Frequency	Percent
1	50 years old and over	2	4%
2	Between 15-30 years old	19	37%
3	Between 31-40 years old	21	40%
4	Between 41-50 years old	10	19%

Regarding gender representation among survey participants, both male and female were actively involved. Male constituted the majority of survey respondents, accounting for 48%, followed closely by female participants at 46%. A minority, constituting 6%, chose not to disclose their gender category during the survey. The gender distribution of the participants is visually represented in the graph below.

Figure 1: Contribution of survey participants by gender



VI. PART ONE: HOUSING

Housing for Afghan newcomers to Canada presents a multifaceted challenge. Newcomers often face difficulties due to high rent costs, especially in regions with competitive housing markets. Discrimination by landlords can further exacerbate these challenges. Additionally, unfamiliarity with Canada's housing system and a lack of prior credit history can complicate the process of securing accommodations. "Calgary is experiencing a housing crisis. One in five Calgary households are unable to afford where they currently live. That's over 84,600 households who are spending more than 30% of their income on housing³."

For those with larger families, finding suitable housing that meets their needs can be particularly daunting. These factors underscore the importance of providing comprehensive support and resources to aid Afghan newcomers in their housing journey and ensure their successful integration into their new Canadian homes.

³ Calgary's housing strategy 2024 – 2030:

<https://www.calgary.ca/communities/housing-in-calgary/housing-strategy.html#:~:text=Calgary%20is%20experiencing%20a%20housing,of%20their%20income%20on%20housing.>

A significant proportion of survey respondents have established their residences in the northeastern regions of the country, as indicated by the survey data. Among the four regions specified for participants to identify their place of residence, the majority, accounting for 56%, are situated in the northeast. A breakdown of respondents' living regions is provided in the table below for further clarity.

Table 2: Contribution of survey participants by living regions

<i>Sn</i>	<i>Regions</i>	<i>Frequency</i>	<i>Percent</i>
1	Northeast	29	56%
2	Northwest	8	15%
3	Southeast	4	8%
4	Southwest	11	21%

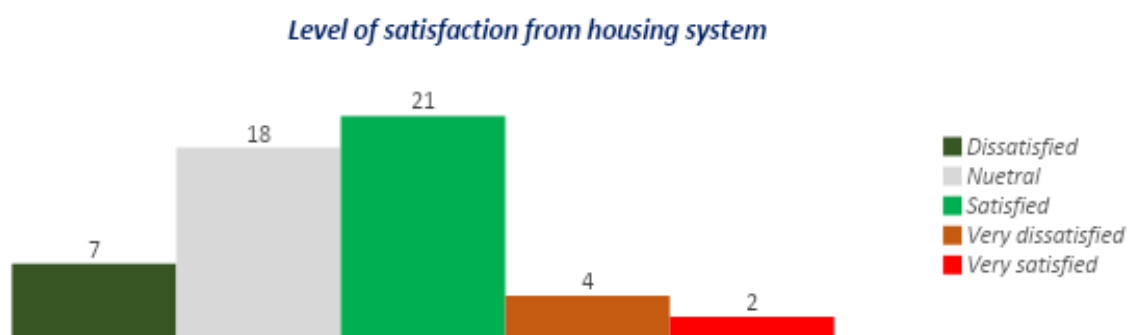
Newcomers exhibit diverse preferences when it comes to the type of residential housing they choose. These residential options are categorized into apartments, single houses, townhouses, and other categories. Notably, survey respondents equally favor single houses and apartments as their primary living arrangements, each accounting for 31% of the total.

Table 3: Contribution of survey participants by residential housing

<i>Sn</i>	<i>Type Of Residentials</i>	<i>Frequency</i>	<i>Percent</i>
1	Apartment	16	31%
2	Other	6	12%
3	Single house	16	31%
4	Townhouse	14	27%

Regarding the satisfaction levels of participants with their chosen housing types, a higher percentage of 40% expressed satisfaction or very satisfaction with their current living arrangements. However, responses to this Likert question unveil a lower percentage of newcomers registering dissatisfaction or providing neutral responses. These results are visually depicted in the accompanying bar graph below.

Figure 2: Level of satisfaction from housing system



For the majority of newcomers, the process of securing housing typically spanned several months. Nevertheless, it is worth noting that a portion of the participants managed to secure suitable housing within a remarkably short timeframe, as detailed in the table provided below:

Table 4: Time spent searching for housing facilities.

<i>Sn</i>	<i>Period searched for housing</i>	<i>Frequency</i>	<i>Percent</i>
1	<i>Couple of months</i>	18	35%
2	<i>A month</i>	17	33%
3	<i>More than two months</i>	14	27%
4	<i>A week</i>	3	6%

A significant proportion of newcomers took the initiative to independently locate their housing by actively engaging in local market searches. Among the survey respondents, 56% directly interacted with landlords to secure their housing through lease agreements. In contrast, the remaining participants identified their housing options through the assistance of resettlement agencies, service providers, or friends who served as co-signers for lease agreements.

Newcomers to Canada face a range of complex challenges when seeking housing. These challenges include accommodating larger families, coping with high rent costs exacerbated by landlord discrimination, navigating an unfamiliar housing system, and dealing with the lack of a credit history in Canada. These issues often intertwine, creating a formidable barrier to finding suitable housing.

Sohail Shafaq, who was a journalist and television presenter in Afghanistan before the collapse of the former republic government, touched on the existing discrimination by landlords in Calgary in an interview with CTV News Calgary. “Last night I was got an appointment to see one home, but when we see the home, and we accept that to get this home for rent, the owner of (the) home said where you from are? We said Afghanistan. ‘Oh, I was thinking you are from Ukraine.’ Like that they rejected(us) directly,” said Shafaq⁴.

“Refugees like Shafaq are having a difficult time finding permanent housing due to a lack of affordable rental options in Calgary and systemic biases” said Anil Lee Yuen, President and CEO of Centre for Newcomers.

This underscores the importance of providing comprehensive support and resources to aid newcomers in their housing journey and ensure equitable access to housing opportunities.

VII. PART TWO: EMPLOYMENT

Employment for Afghan newcomers in Canada is a critical aspect of their resettlement journey. Newcomers often encounter challenges related to the recognition of foreign qualifications, language barriers, and limited local networks. These factors can hinder their access to suitable job opportunities, potentially leading to underemployment or unemployment. Organizations and programs that offer language training, credential recognition, and job placement support play a crucial role in assisting Afghan newcomers in overcoming these obstacles and finding meaningful employment that aligns with their skills and aspirations. Facilitating their entry into the Canadian workforce is pivotal to their successful integration and economic self-sufficiency.

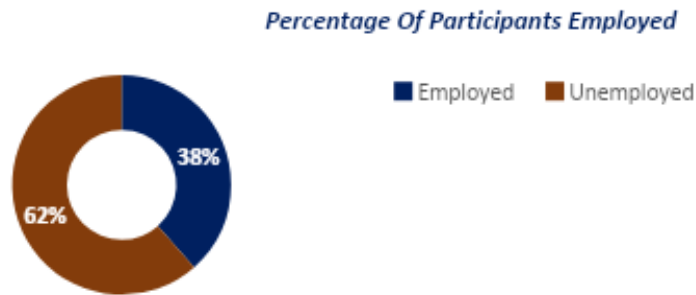
Even the settlement service providers have laid off their skilled employees including Afghan newcomer refugees due to inflation, and government budget cuts. “Kelly Ernst, CFN chief program officer, says the waves of Afghan and Ukrainian newcomers have stretched programs. He said fortunately, CFN was previously able to work with the government to ensure they were able to provide the services necessary

⁴ CTV News: <https://calgary.ctvnews.ca/afghan-refugees-struggle-to-locate-calgary-housing-1.6106827>

for resettlement. However now, with the contracts not extended, CFN will have to scale back programming⁵.”

In response to the question regarding the current employment status of survey participants, it is evident from the data that the majority, representing 62% responded negatively, signifying that they are not presently employed. In contrast, the remaining 38% of respondents are actively engaged in the Canadian job market, currently holding employment.

Figure 3: Participants’ employment status



Approximately 65% of employed respondents are engaged in full-time positions, working between 31-40 hours per week. The remaining portion of employed individuals are working in casual or part-time capacities, dedicating either 10-19 hours or 20-30 hours per week to their respective roles.

According to survey respondents, challenges for not having a job include inflation, language barriers, lack of networking skills, increased competition due to a refugee influx, limited job opportunities, and a lack of effective employment counseling from settlement service providers.

A noteworthy observation from the survey data is the limited access to skills building training and career development workshops among respondents since their arrival in Canada. The data indicates that the majority, comprising 17 out of 52 respondents, have not had the opportunity to participate in these programs. This situation highlights a potential gap in the provision of essential resources and support for newcomers seeking to enhance their skills, integrate into the Canadian job market, and advance their careers. These findings underscore the importance of addressing these disparities and ensuring that more newcomers have access to skill-building opportunities, ultimately facilitating their successful integration into the Canadian workforce.

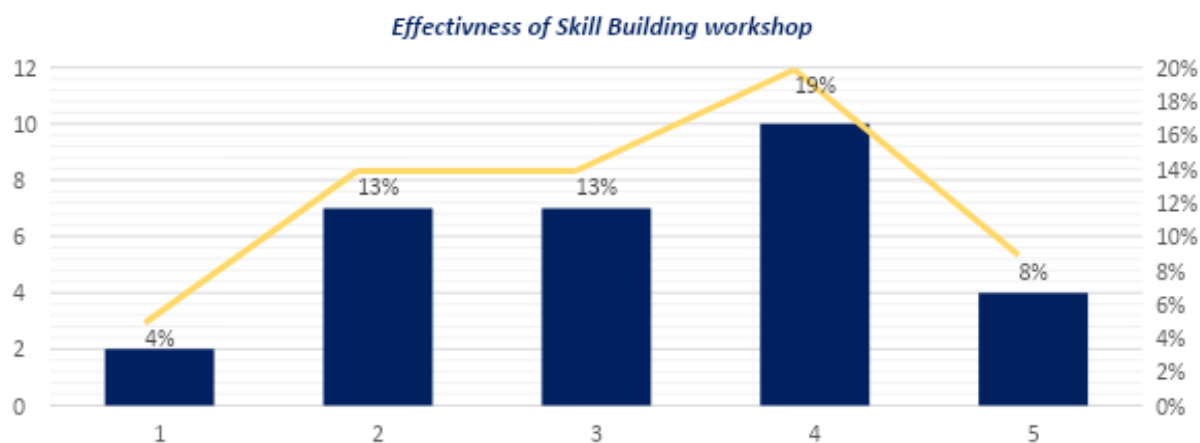
Table 5: Participants attending skills building and career workshops.

<i>Sn</i>	<i>Skill building Training</i>	<i>Frequency</i>	<i>Percent</i>
1	No, I haven't	35	67%
2	Yes, I received	17	33%

The effectiveness of skill-building and career training workshops has generated differing opinions among participants. A significant portion, accounting for approximately 33%, considers these workshops as "somehow effective." However, there are also respondents who find them to be "Not at all helpful" or "Not so helpful." A detailed breakdown of the Likert scale responses is illustrated in the bar graph below for further insight and reference.

⁵ Global News: <https://globalnews.ca/news/9821970/calgary-centre-for-newcomers-layoffs/>

Figure 4: effectiveness of skills building, and career workshops rated by survey participants.



VIII. PART THREE: EDUCATION

Language proficiency represents a substantial barrier for newcomers, notably among Afghan refugees in Calgary. While a significant proportion exhibits a reasonable command of the English language, a larger segment possesses only a limited grasp of English. Comprehensive details can be found in the table below.

Table 6: Participants' English Language Skill

<i>SN</i>	<i>English Language Skills</i>	<i>Frequency</i>	<i>Percent</i>
1	<i>A little</i>	<i>21</i>	<i>40%</i>
2	<i>No</i>	<i>5</i>	<i>10%</i>
3	<i>Yes</i>	<i>26</i>	<i>50%</i>

The majority of survey respondents, constituting 54%, are currently enrolled in the Language Instruction for Newcomers to Canada (LINC) program⁶, which offers vital English language support. However, there are other participants who are either not attending the LINC program or have limited information about it. This diversity in enrollment reflects the varied language support experiences among survey participants.

The educational qualifications of the survey participants are representative of a broad spectrum of backgrounds. A significant majority, comprising 58% of the respondents, possess high school diplomas. Furthermore, 21% of the participants have earned bachelor's degrees, while 15% have attained master's degrees, and 6% hold technical certifications. This diverse educational landscape underscores the variety of academic and professional experiences within the surveyed group, enriching the overall diversity of the sample.

While a significant number of Afghan refugees who are newcomers to Canada hold higher degrees, a substantial portion of these degree holders have not taken steps to validate or evaluate their educational

⁶ LINC program is for adult immigrants and refugees (18 years of age or older) who need to develop necessary language and life skills to actively function in the Canadian society

qualifications through internationally recognized agencies such as WES and IQAS. The survey data highlights that approximately 48% of respondents have not undertaken this educational document evaluation process. For a more detailed breakdown of responses related to educational document evaluation, see the table below.

Table 7: *Participants' Education Document Evaluation.*

<i>Sn</i>	<i>Status of Educational document evaluation</i>	<i>Frequency</i>	<i>Percent</i>
<i>1</i>	<i>I don't know about IQAS or WES</i>	<i>16</i>	<i>31%</i>
<i>2</i>	<i>I don't want to submit</i>	<i>1</i>	<i>2%</i>
<i>3</i>	<i>No</i>	<i>25</i>	<i>48%</i>
<i>4</i>	<i>Yes</i>	<i>10</i>	<i>19%</i>

In response to inquiries about their intentions to pursue further educational opportunities, the survey data reveals that a significant majority, representing 75% of respondents, have not yet embarked on the process of applying for educational continuation. This statistic underscores a prevailing trend among Afghan newcomers, indicating a substantial portion who have yet to seek further academic pursuits.

Afghan newcomers pursuing education continuation in Canada encounter various challenges. The process of certifying educational documents through agencies like IQAS or WES can be intricate, leading to complications in some cases. Additionally, missing transcripts and difficulties accessing their degree or diploma pose hurdles. For many, meeting English language requirements is a prerequisite, and not meeting these requirements further impedes their educational journey. Some respondents experience a combination of challenges, including both English language requirements and document accessibility issues. These barriers feature the importance of tailored support and resources for newcomers striving to continue their education in Canada.

IX. PART FOUR: RECOMMENDATIONS

In the recommendations section, survey respondents provided suggestions to both resettlement agencies and the federal government.

Survey participants provided practical recommendations to settlement service providers in Calgary to improve their services in the areas of Housing, Education, and Employment for newcomers. They stress the importance of providing practical guidance, not just information, on tasks like enrolling children in school and accessing services. Respondents emphasize the need for information about the Canadian funding system and support for employment and education, recognizing the skills newcomers bring from their home countries. Finding work and affordable housing is a shared concern.

They call for well-trained settlement counselors and more comprehensive assistance, particularly for those facing economic challenges. Respondents also advocate for government intervention in housing and emphasize the need for effective job fairs, enhanced housing counseling services, and a mechanism to monitor service organizations. They highlight the importance of affordable housing and employment.

Respondents provide recommendations to the provincial and federal government of Canada on improving settlement services for newcomers in the areas of Housing, Education, and Employment:

They recognize the pressing need for measures like rent control, suggesting the establishment of an organization to oversee rent prices, thereby aiding immigrant families grappling with housing cost challenges. Furthermore, they stress the importance of providing comprehensive support for both work and affordable housing, prioritizing stability in the newcomers' lives.

In addition to these housing-related recommendations, the respondents emphasize the significance of having supportive workers who can understand and address newcomers' needs, providing guidance and assistance. They advocate for initiatives that match newcomers' skills with potential employers, whether as interns or through other pathways, thereby enabling them to gain valuable Canadian work experience. To facilitate integration, the suggestion to provide multilingual information and free English courses stands out.

There is also a call for robust monitoring of settlement agencies to ensure the quality of their services. Planning for refugee housing in advance of their arrival is seen as essential to ensuring suitable accommodations. Tailored job opportunities for newcomers and enhanced services, particularly in their native languages, focusing on education and housing affordability, are proposed to support their successful integration into Canadian society. These recommendations underscore the importance of a holistic approach to settlement services, addressing newcomers' needs comprehensively.

X. CONCLUSION

In conclusion, this report offers a comprehensive overview of the challenges faced by Afghan newcomers as they embark on their journey of resettlement in Canada. These challenges span housing, employment, education, and integration into Canadian society. The findings underscore the multifaceted nature of these difficulties, emphasizing the need for tailored support and resources to ensure a successful transition for these newcomers.

Housing, a fundamental concern for newcomers, highlights the pressing issues of high rent costs, discrimination, and navigating an unfamiliar housing system. In this context, support mechanisms must be established to help newcomers secure suitable accommodations, especially those with larger families.

Employment is another critical aspect of resettlement, with language barriers, limited job opportunities, and underutilized skills posing significant challenges. The data demonstrates the importance of initiatives that match newcomers' qualifications with available job opportunities, along with comprehensive language support.

Education continues to play a pivotal role in the lives of newcomers, with a range of educational backgrounds present among participants. Addressing challenges such as document certification and language proficiency is essential to facilitating their academic pursuits.

The recommendations provided by survey respondents highlight the critical role of government agencies and settlement service providers in addressing these challenges. Practical guidance, information about funding systems, tailored job opportunities, and expanding support for language and educational resources are all key components of the recommended solutions.

In summary, this report serves as a valuable resource for understanding the complex challenges faced by Afghan newcomers in Canada. It underscores the importance of a holistic approach to their resettlement, emphasizing the need for support, resources, and tailored services to ensure their successful integration into Canadian society. By addressing these challenges, Canada can enhance the experience and prospects of Afghan newcomers and contribute to their long-term well-being and prosperity in their new home.

The End

ANNEX A: SURVEY QUESTIONNAIRE

Afghan Newcomers' Settlement Issues Survey

Purpose: This questionnaire is designed to assess the settlement and integration journey of Afghan newcomers in Calgary AB, Canada. The data from respondents will be gathered, and analyzed as research, and will be shared with non-profit organizations.

Confidentiality: Your responses will be kept confidential, and we are not asking from you to provide your personal identification information.

Thank you in advance for taking part in this survey.

Respondent's Gender: Male _____ Female _____ Other _____

Respondent's Age

- ☐ Between 18 - 30
- ☐ Between 31 - 40
- ☐ Between 41 - 50
- ☐ More than 50 years / 50 +

Where do you live in Calgary?

- ☐ Northeast
- ☐ Northwest
- ☐ Southeast
- ☐ Southwest

Part One: Housing

What type of house do you live in?

- ☐ Townhouse
- ☐ Single House
- ☐ Apartment
- ☐ Other

How satisfied are you living in this house/apartment?

- ☐ Very satisfied
- ☐ Satisfied
- ☐ Neutral
- ☐ Dissatisfied
- ☐ Very dissatisfied

How long did it take you to find and lease the house?

- ☐ A week
- ☐ A month

- ___ A couple of months
___ More than two months

Did you find the house, or a settlement service provider helped you find a house?

- ___ I found it myself.
___ A settlement service provider
___ A friend found and co-signed.

What challenges have you faced in finding a home during your settlement process in Canada? Please select one or more from below:

- ☐ High price rent
☐ No prior credit history in Canada
☐ No knowledge of Canada's housing system
☐ Faced Discrimination by landlord
☐ Having more family members

PART II: EMPLOYMENT

Do you currently have a job or being employed?

- ___ Yes
___ No

If yes, how many hours a week do you work?

- ☐ Full-time (31-40 hours a week)
☐ Part-time (20-30 hours a week)
☐ Casual (10-19 hours a week)
☐ Unemployed

If no, why? Please select one or all if apply.

- ___ Inflation
___ No English language proficiency
___ No networking skills
___ Refugee influx to Canada
___ No effective employment counselling by settlement service providers
___ Limited job opportunities for newcomers

Have you received any skill building trainings or any career building certified workshops?

Yes, I received ___ No, I have not ____

If yes, were the training workshops helpful to support you find a job/employment?

- ☐ Extremely helpful
- ☐ Very helpful
- ☐ Somewhat helpful
- ☐ Not so helpful
- ☐ Not at all helpful

PART III: EDUCATION

Can you speak English language?

Yes: _____ A little _____ No _____

Do you study English as part of Language Instruction for Newcomers to Canada (LINC)?

Yes: _____ No _____ It is in the process _____ I don't know about LINC _____

What is the highest level of your education?

- ☐ PhD
- ☐ Master's degree
- ☐ High school certificate
- ☐ Technical certificate
- ☐ Other: If other, please specify _____

Did you or anyone on behalf of you submit your educational documents (degree/diploma) for credential through World Education Services (WES) or International Qualification Assessment Services (IQAS) in Canada?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No
- ☐ I don't know about WES or IQAS
- ☐ I don't want to submit for evaluation

Have you applied to continue your education and to upgrade your credentials?

Yes _____ No _____ Not yet _____

If yes, what challenges have you faced during application? Select one or many from below:

- ☐ Not meeting English language requirement.
- ☐ Inaccessibility to my degree/diploma
- ☐ Complicated process of certification of educational documents by WES or IQAS
- ☐ Other

PART V: RECOMMENDATIONS

What are your suggestions or recommendations to settlement service providers to improve their services on Housing, Education and Employment for newcomers in Calgary?

.....
.....

What are your suggestions or recommendation to provincial and federal government of Canada to improve their settlement services on Housing, Education and Employment for newcomers in Canada?

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